

PRE-COLUMBIAN WEAPONRY

Weapons technology did not advance significantly in the Americas in the thousand years before European contact in the late 15th century. The most common weapons were thrusting spears, slings, and wooden clubs, with padded cotton armour forming the principal protection. Warfare, although common (especially between the Mayan cities of Mesoamerica), occurred on a small scale until the 14th and 15th centuries. This period saw the emergence of the more organized Inca and Aztec states, which were able to construct large empires dominating most of Peru and Mexico, respectively. It was their ability to deploy resources effectively, rather than superior military technology, that ensured their supremacy.

► MAYAN AXEHEAD

Date 9th century CE

Origin Mexico

Length 32cm (12½in)

Material Obsidian

Axes were not commonly employed by Mayan warriors in battle – this axehead bearing the form of human silhouettes was probably ceremonial. The Mayans instead used mainly spears and long clubs.



Human silhouette

Small human head



Gold headdress

Cavity for turquoise decoration

Image of Sicán Lord

▼ MIXTEC GOLD BREASTPLATE

Date 1300–1450CE

Origin Mexico

Material Gold

This gold breastplate in the form of a deity came from the Mixtec people of Monte Alban, near modern-day Oaxaca. Mixtec nobles fought with thrusting spears, while commoners probably used slings and *atlatls*.



Face of Mixtec god

Wide, semi-circular blade

▲ CEREMONIAL TUMI

Date 9–11th century CE

Origin Peru

Length Approx. 35cm (13¾in)

Material Gold, bronze

Tumis were ceremonial knives with semicircular blades, characteristic of the Sicán and the Moche, pre-Inca peoples of Peru. They depicted the mythical founder of the Sicán people, the Sicán Lord, and were used in sacrifices to slit the victim's throat.

► AZTEC CHIMALLI

Date 1400–1500

Origin Mexico

Diameter 75cm (30in)

An Aztec warrior's *chimalli* (shield) was usually made of fire-hardened bamboo, tied together with fibres from the maguey plant. They were backed with cotton or leather and covered with feathers, which often hung down in tassels. The object pictured here is a replica.

